

featherweight champion, defending his title against the unbeaten Ilia Topuria at the Honda Centre Arena in California.

Sixth title defense for The Great

Volkanovski, nicknamed *The Great*, has successfully defended his belt five times before this fight. However, he has been unsuccessful in his attempt to become the UFC's fifth multi-weight champion. He suffered two losses in his previous three fights, both of which were against Islam Makhachev, the world's No. 1 men's pound-for-pound (skill-based ranking irrespective of weight class) grappler, while fighting for the lightweight title.

The first fight between Volkanovski and Makhachev, which lasted five rounds, was recognised as the Fight of the Year. The second fight, however, damaged Volkanovski's reputation when Makhachev knocked him out with a left-high kick that was well-executed and perfectly timed.

Despite the two losses, Volkanovski's dominance in the featherweight division was proven in the fight between his two losses. He highlighted his legacy in his division at UFC 290 at the T-Mobile Arena in Las Vegas.

When Volkanovski switched his weight class, Yair Rodriguez, a.k.a. El Pantera, became the interim featherweight champion. With the belt and his pride on the line, Volkanovski successfully took down Rodriguez seven times out of 12 and landed a right hook to his face, which left Rodriguez vulnerable. Volkanovski seized the opportunity and used powerful strikes to knock his opponent out.

On the other hand, undefeated challenger Topuria has won all six of his UFC fights and earned three consecutive performance bonuses before his first title fight.

Topuria's striking skills were on display in his UFC main event debut, where he fought Josh Emmett in a Fight of the Night award-winning match. Although he did not finish the fight, his impressive display

Fiery days ahead: Defending featherweight champion Alexander Volkanovski takes on an unbeaten Ilia Topuria in UFC 299 at the Honda Centre Arena in California. AFP

confirmed his status as a title contender and put him next in line for a championship shot.

On an equal footing

One of the major reasons for Volkanovski's long-term success is his endurance. While other fighters tend to wear down as the rounds progress, *The Great* is at his volatile best in the fifth round. Four out of his five title fight wins have lasted the full 25 minutes. Volkanovski averages 6.91 significant strikes per minute in the first four rounds but ups his game in the final five, averaging 7.52 significant strikes per minute.

Volkanovski's strong suit is his durability, while Topuria has superior power.

His six first-round submission wins are a testament to his striking prowess. Averaging close to one knockdown (forcing an opponent to fall down with a strike) per minute, Topuria will be a litmus test for Volkanovski's stamina.

Blockbuster fights

A fight that was supposed to happen a year ago will finally see the light of day. Robert Whittaker will take on Paulo Costa, who pulled out of UFC 284 due to an alleged dispute with the promotion, in a middleweight bout.

Meanwhile, initially paired off last summer as well, Geoff Neal and Ian Machado Garry will finally share the Octagon together.

A fixture in the top 15 in the welterweight rankings for the last several years, Neal combined with Shavkat Rakhmonov for one of the best fights of the year in 2023, but unfortunately for the Fortis MMA product, he landed on the wrong side of the results. Machado Garry has yet to occupy that position in his career, bringing a 13-0 record into his seventh UFC assignment.



Main card for UFC 298



Featherweight championship
Alexander Volkanovski vs. Ilia Topuria

Middleweight
Robert Whittaker vs. Paulo Costa

Welterweight:
Geoff Neal vs. Ian Garry

Bantamweight
Merab Dvalishvili vs. Henry Cejudo

Middleweight
Anthony Hernandez vs. Ikram Aliskerov